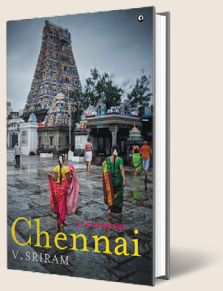
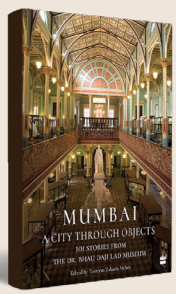
TALE OF THREE CITIES

New books that lead us through the urban maze



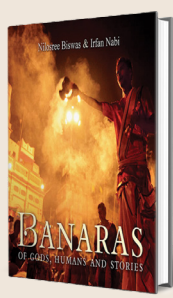
CHENNAI
A Biography
by V. Sriram
ALEPH
₹899;
440 pages

Making the claim that Madras was modern India's first substantial city, Sriram tells us the story of the city's achievements and building. Journeying through Chennai's past, it arrives at the present beautifully.



MUMBAI
A City Through Objects
by Tasneem Zakaria Mehta
HARPERCOLLINS
₹2,999;
372 pages

Built in 1872, the Dr Bhau Daji Lad Museum is, of course, a repository of all things old, but it's many artefacts also explain Mumbai's present. In this book, Mehta chooses 101 objects that can time-travel.



BANARAS
Of Gods, Humans and Stories
by Nilosree Biswas & Irfan Habib
NIYOGI BOOKS
₹1,750; 240 pages

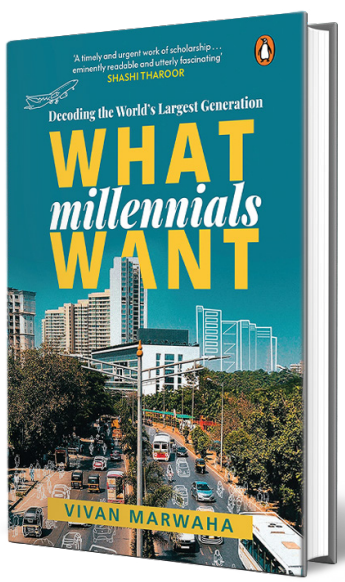
It can sometimes be hard to make sense of Banaras' sacred geography, but author Nilosree Biswas and photographer Irfan Habib wonderfully navigate Kashi's mythic labyrinth in this lush coffee-table book.

BOOKS

STARS *in Their* EYES

Vivan Marwaha's examination of India's millennial culture is weighed down by its predictability

WHAT MILLENNIALS WANT
Decoding the Largest Generation in the World
by Vivan Marwaha
PENGUIN VIKING
₹599; 238 pages



Vivan Marwaha's *What Millennials Want* is the latest addition to the trickle of books on 'Young India'. It tells us nothing we don't know already, from the practice of arranged marriages to the primacy of religion. Moreover, Marwaha's conclusions have a stirring blandness. On demonetisation: "This is a generation that supports bold action." The book ends with a *sarkari* insight: "India's millennials are defined by their diversity, talent and potential, and they currently stand at a crossroads." The author tries to rescue the impoverished observation with the braggadocio of scope: "...having camped out across 13 Indian states talking to more than 900 millennials, I can write with confidence..."

VIVAN MARWAHA'S individual stories rarely give us flesh and blood; he is unable to make us 'see' the characters

Marwaha is a master at stating the obvious, which he thinks the use of italics will hide: a government job is a "*one-way ticket to a better life*". A 'user researcher' by profession, his obsession with 'expansive data sets' means that the reader will find herself drowning in a sea of statistics. The individual stories rarely give us flesh and blood; the author is unable to make us 'see' the characters. Their only role is to illustrate the stats.

The 'Young India' genre has become predictable: A trip to the Infosys headquarters, the chat with the Uber driver, the coffee shop worker and literacy numbers from the NGO Pratham. The unimaginative chapter headings—'Education', 'Marriage and Social Views', 'Political Attitudes'—are reminiscent of a quaint Talcott Parsons sociology tome.

Even if the Infosys campus has been done to death, new eyes can show it afresh. Instead, we are given meaningless numbers: the largest auditorium can seat 1,024 people; the campus has 16,485 beds.

The prose style deploys hackneyed tactics like beginning a sentence with a pointless reference to the weather: "It was a humid day in South Mumbai in May 2018"; "It was a rainy morning in August 2018". There is the occasional funny moment, like when Marwaha gets unduly excited watching a man on the metro swiping a dating app for men, only to discover the man is a father looking for grooms for his daughter on Shaadi.com.

There are good bits: The schoolteacher in Bihar who gets a student to apply henna during a lesson; how algorithms of food delivery and cab hailing apps are rigged in favour of the capitalist; an interesting aside on Sumeet Samos, a Dalit rapper from Odisha; how Indian millennials marry very young and "have a spouse and children to consider when making economic decisions". He is excellent when discussing selfie culture and 'digital agency': "A cool pout at the security line, a dashing Bollywood pose at the aerobridge, a seductive smile on seat 34D—no moment was too small for this excited young traveller." ■

—Palash Krishna Mehrotra